

THE DISCIPLINE OF COMPOSURE

Composure, Dupuis insists, isn't passive. "In turbulent times, composure requires disciplined effort," he says. "As CEO of a global HR firm operating across India, Japan, and beyond, I learned leaders must anchor themselves in values before reacting to headlines."

His leadership compass: "Control the controllables and face the non-controllables with agility." He recalls navigating the pandemic and US-China trade tensions: "Strong leaders made the right calls, they sought advice and acted on facts not speculation. Those who prioritised employee safety, business continuity, and long-term trust came out stronger."

Calm, Dupuis adds, is contagious. "A composed leader is not

agility when US-China tensions flared. They didn't release statements or take sides. Instead, they restructured their supply chain diplomatically." Toyota followed a similar approach, continuing to invest simultaneously in the US and China without becoming politically entangled.

A powerful cautionary tale comes from the NBA-China incident in 2019. One tweet from an NBA team executive expressing support for Hong Kong protests triggered a nearly six-year blackout of NBA broadcasts in China, cutting off a market of over 500 million viewers. Only now, years later, is the NBA rebuilding its China presence.

His takeaway is sharp: "In geopolitics, raising one's voice is not a virtue. Leaders should speak

reflect that.' When values are universal, employees rally even when politics differ."

Inside companies, Jha believes the CCO—Chief Communications Officer—should lead this domain. "CCOs can straddle corporate affairs, geopolitical intelligence, and communications strategy," he says.

Balancing ethical expectations with realpolitik, Jha distinguishes between ethics and geopolitics. Conscientious CEOs must take decisions in the interest of all stakeholders, as far as possible. Ethical expectations and geopolitical realities, however, are two very different dimensions.

TO BE CEO-READY

If Dupuis frames geopolitical intelligence as a lived discipline, Prasad Medury, Chairman-India, Odgers, a global executive search and leadership advisory firm, situates it within the evolving science of leadership assessment.

"Geopolitical awareness and cross-cultural sensitivity," he says, "have moved to the core of modern leadership competency frameworks."

The hunt for global fluency has intensified. "CEO briefs explicitly seek evidence of lived experience in complex geographies, constructive engagement with governments and regulators," Medury notes. "And this bar now applies beyond the CEO; C-suite leaders are expected to demonstrate global fluency at some level too."

For boards and search firms, the question isn't just whether leaders can respond, but whether they can do so with diplomacy. "We evaluate competencies like conflict resolution, learning agility, strategic clarity, influencing skills, and thinking dexterity," says Medury. "These competencies are

90 | "IN GEOPOLITICS, RAISING ONE'S VOICE IS NOT A VIRTUE. LEADERS SHOULD SPEAK THROUGH THEIR ACTIONS, NOT EMOTIONS. ACT WITH CONVICTION AND SENSITIVITY"

the one who simply waits for the storm to pass, but the one who acts with calm urgency, balancing realism with optimism. That steadiness of the leader becomes the organisation's stabiliser."

NEUTRALITY V/S SILENCE

On neutrality versus silence, Dupuis strikes a nuanced balance. "Younger generations want moral clarity, not corporate caution." There are moments when leaders need to step up, show courage and take a stance rooted in values.

Dupuis cites examples of leaders who struck this balance well. "Apple showed quiet geopolitical

through their actions, not emotions. Act with conviction and sensitivity."

COMMUNICATION IS KEY

Communication, meanwhile, has become a minefield. The Edelman Trust Barometer 2024—an annual global report that measures public trust in institutions—found that 71% of employees expect CEOs to speak on societal issues but they don't want activism; they want clarity. Dupuis warns against reactive statements.

His rule of thumb: "Don't say, 'We support X or oppose Y.' A wiser stance is: 'We care for our people everywhere, and our actions will